followed Philip II on the Fourth Crusade but had left it at Zara, when it began to lose its focus. Now Montfort became the strategist and driving force of the Albigensian Crusade and, soon, the agent of its greatest cruelties.

After wintering in Languedoc, Montfort led the Crusader armies westward across southern Francia. In the spring of 1210, he arrived at the town of Bram, protected only by a wall and single gate from attack. Inside Bram, once again, Catholics and Cathars joined to fight against the attack.

Within three days, Bram fell, and Montfort displayed for the first time the vindictiveness that would mark his campaigning. As punishment for resisting the armies of God, he ordered the eyes of the defenders put out ("over a hundred in number," says Pierre des Vaux de Cernay) and their noses cut off.[14]

After Bram, a string of towns and castles fell to Crusader attack: Alaric, Termes, Lastours, and Minerve, where Monfort ordered 140 captured "perfected heretics" burned alive, both men and women.

And watching Montfort and his companions laying claim to one tract of Languedoc land after another, Raymond VI of Toulouse began to see that the Crusade would, ultimately, bring an end not just to Catharism but to his own power.